EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 8 OCTOBER 2026

Ojai, California

In the Ojai Valley, El Niño's danger is where people are standing when an atmospheric river arrives: in a canyon below a failing road, in a Casitas Springs or Live Oak Acres home beside the creek, or in a car at a flooded crossing. Then the valley is cut off, sometimes for months. The most important step is a plain, address-level warning and a knock on the door for the few hundred people in those places, written now and triggered by the storm forecast, not by the El Niño label.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Ventura County, CA (inferred)	None published for the US, California, or the county	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000	Atmospheric-river floods and debris on the Ventura River, San Antonio Creek, and Matilija; the valley cut off when Highways 33 and 150 close; outages

12/12 recommendations checked. 0 confirmed outright, 10 corrected, 1 unverified, 1 contraindicated: flat City cash grants released on a rain-gauge trigger, which California's gift-of-public-funds clause makes the weakest legal form of aid. The funding placements were checked separately. The storm-night motel placement mostly duplicates the City of

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



34.45°N 119.24°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** The danger is where people are standing when an atmospheric river arrives: in a canyon, beside a creek, or at a flooded crossing; the valley can then be cut off, sometimes for months.
- **First action.** Ventura County OES, County Fire, and Ojai Valley CERT write address-level evacuation messages for the canyons and levee neighbourhoods by 1 November, and knock on doors at each atmospheric-river watch.*
- **The money.** $187k floor, $407k target, $556k ceiling; the floor starts with $77k for HELP of Ojai, including 60 power stations.
- **Do not.** Do not have the City pay flat cash grants automatically when the Ojai rain gauge crosses a threshold.

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Ventura's existing Foul Weather Shelter program, and the river-bottom camps it serves are in Ventura, not the Ojai Valley. It was cut from $100k to $40k. The funding target fell 26%, from $550k to $407k, which is within the one-third tolerance. Exposure: Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk, September 2026, pre-peer-review. It publishes no figure for the United States, California, or Ventura County, and heat is not this place's winter hazard. No population-scaled figure is given here.

Read this first: El Niño raises Ojai's odds; it does not set the date. Of the 166 NFIP flood claims paid in ZIP 93023 since 1978, 84 came in two winters: 1998 (40, a very strong El Niño) and 2005 (44, a weak one). But the strong 2015–16 El Niño left Southern California dry, and the storm that cut the valley off for most of a year, on 9–10 January 2023, came in a La Niña winter. That storm closed about 32 miles of Highway 33 from 10 January to 18 December 2023 (about $35M in repairs), and about 70 Matilija Canyon residents were airlifted out. Trigger every action on an atmospheric-river forecast. If this winter starts dry, do not stand down, and do not sell the work as an “El Niño campaign” that a dry January would discredit.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO — RANKED

Actions are ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. The backing lenses are shown on each action, and the RACI chart below assigns each one. One rule underlies every action: deaths here depend on where people are standing, not on how old the valley is. Count and reach the people in the canyons, behind the levees, in mobile homes, and on the roads, address by address.

1. Pre-write address-level evacuation warnings and orders for the canyons and the levee neighbourhoods, and back them with door knocks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Ventura County Sheriff's Office of Emergency Services (VC Alert / Genasys); Ventura County Fire; Ojai Valley CERT for door knocks	Messages written by 1 Nov; knocks on each atmospheric-river watch	Staff and volunteer time	Deaths among people who think a “voluntary” warning does not apply to them

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Cover Matilija Canyon and North Fork, Camino Cielo, Creek Road and Camp Comfort, Casitas Springs, Live Oak Acres, Camp Chaffee, and the mobile-home parks: ZIP 93023 has 1,484 mobile homes, 15.7% of its housing. Write one plain-language order per address, not zone lines drawn on roads. The lesson comes from next door: in the January 2018 Montecito debris flow, 19 of the 23 dead lived south of Highway 192, in the “voluntary” zone. In an NWS and University of Alabama survey of 404 residents, 25% were unsure which zone they were in, and compliance barely improved between the January and March orders (UCSB, 2021).*

Corrections: Ventura County already issues alerts for these places by name (Matilija, North Fork, and Camino Cielo orders, and Creek Road warnings, in February 2024), so the work is pre-writing and address-level targeting, not a new system. Whether the county ties orders to the San Antonio Creek or Foster Park gauges, the Genasys zone IDs for Live Oak Acres and Camp Chaffee, NOAA Weather Radio coverage, and the claims of no sirens and no cell signal in Matilija were not verified. Montecito's early count (15 of 21) was later revised to 19 of 23.

2. Reach the 192 Medicare beneficiaries on powered medical equipment: Medical Baseline, SCE's free backup battery, and a loan pool for the rest

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST · SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MGR | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Ventura County Public Health (named emPOWER request); SCE (Medical Baseline and Critical Care Backup Battery); HELP of Ojai (loan pool)	**Named-list request and enrolment in October; batteries by 1 Dec**	**Battery free from SCE; ~$39k for 60 power stations for those not enrolled (see funding)**	**Deaths from failed oxygen concentrators and other devices in shutoffs and storm outages**

HHS emPOWER, re-queried by the verifier on 8 October 2026, counts 152 electricity-dependent Medicare beneficiaries in ZIP 93023 (of 6,136) and 40 in 93022 (of 1,580). The county has 6,543. SCE's Critical Care Backup Battery is free to customers who are on Medical Baseline, use a powered medical device, and live in a high-fire-risk area. SCE runs PSPS shutoffs on Ojai circuits, so most of the valley should qualify. The gap is people not yet enrolled in Medical Baseline. During California's 2019 PSPS shutoffs, emergency visits among people aged 65 and over rose by 15 per 100,000 on peak days (Harding et al., *Disaster Med Public Health Prep* 2026, a county-day ecological study).*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the public emPOWER data is de-identified; “by name” needs the County to request the named file. Sub-counts showing exactly 11 are the privacy floor, not real numbers. The “4,607 batteries delivered” figure was not found. SCE's portable-power-station rebate is $150, not $200 (the $200 applies to generators). PSPS is a wind-and-fire tool in autumn; winter storm outages are a separate risk that the battery also covers. The 152 matches the count found earlier today for Sacramento ZIP 95818 by coincidence; the beneficiary totals differ.

3. On every atmospheric-river watch, stage a swiftwater team, a dozer, and medical staff inside the valley before the roads close

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Ventura County Fire with Cal OES; Sheriff OES	Standing trigger written by 1 Dec	Staging overtime per event (not quantified)	A rescue force that cannot get in once Highways 33 and 150 and Casitas Pass are shut

Cal OES already pre-positions swiftwater teams, a helicopter, and a dozer in Ventura County before big storms (March 2024 and others), and Ventura County Fire put a swiftwater team on standby when up to 12 inches of rain was forecast for Ojai. What is missing is a written trigger that puts those resources inside the Ojai Valley, not just in the county, before the last road closes. In January 2023 the Matilija airlift took at least 10 sheriff helicopter flights.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the core of this already happens county-wide; the new piece is staging inside the valley. The named staging sites (Nordhoff High School, Ojai Valley Community Hospital) and the claim that every route out, including US-101, closed at once on 9 January 2023 were not verified.

4. Pair everyone who cannot drive with a named neighbour, and plan for 7 to 14 days cut off in Matilija, Upper Ojai, the East End, and Oak View

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
HELP of Ojai (rider outreach, with consent); Ojai Valley CERT; residents	Pairings and printed plans by 1 Dec	~$38k for a staff-run phone register (see funding); volunteer time	Older people stranded without medicine, water, or contact when the roads and the rides stop

ZIP 93023 (21,036 people, ACS 2024) has a median age of 51.9; 30.8% are 65 or over, and 1,759 people aged 65 and over live alone. HELP of Ojai gives weekday door-to-door rides to people aged 60 and over and disabled riders from Casitas Springs to the East End. When the roads close, those riders are the people most likely to be stranded. Ojai Valley CERT is an active Ventura County Fire volunteer program. Put a printed 7-day isolation plan in the *Ojai Valley News*, churches, and clinic waiting rooms, written for both highways closed and the power out.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: HELP of Ojai is at 108 S. Montgomery St.; Kent Hall is the CERT venue, not HELP's address. HELP runs no emergency or wellness-check program today, so this is a new proposal, and sharing its rider list needs each rider's consent. Upper Ojai may be outside its service area.

5. Close flooded crossings physically, and tell drivers to turn around

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
County Public Works (Matilija and Camino Cielo crossings); Caltrans and CHP (Highways 33 and 150); Sheriff OES (coordination)	Closure plan agreed with Caltrans by 1 Dec	Existing operations	Vehicle deaths, the commonest kind of flood death

About 63% of US flood deaths are vehicle-related, in two independent analyses (Ashley & Ashley, *J. Appl. Meteor. Climatol.* 2008, 1959–2005; CIRA 2025, 1996–2023). On 9 January 2023 drivers spent the night stuck in mud on Highway 150 and Casitas Pass. The Thomas Fire's evacuation death near Ojai in December 2017 was also on the road.*

Corrections: the 63% in Ashley & Ashley is cited secondarily and is not in the abstract; the CIRA figure is separate. Highways 33 and 150 are closed by Caltrans and CHP, not county OES, so this needs a Caltrans agreement. These are national figures, not Ojai's.

6. On every flood watch, move unhoused people to a confirmed bed: the older campers on the Ojai City Hall campus, and overflow for the Ventura River bottom

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City of Ojai (City Hall campus); City of Ventura Foul Weather Shelter program (River Community Church); Turning Point Foundation	Protocol by 1 Dec, when Ventura's program opens	$40k overflow beyond Ventura's 40 rooms (see funding)	A repeat of the January 2023 island rescue

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

On 9 January 2023, 18 people were rescued from an island camp on the Ventura River near Main and Peking streets: 7 by ladder, 7 by helicopter, and 4 who walked out. Nobody was hospitalised. That camp is downstream in the City of Ventura, not in Ojai. Ventura's Foul Weather Shelter program already runs 40 motel rooms from 1 December to 31 March. It activates when forecasts show more than about half an inch of overnight rain or temperatures below 40°F, and prioritises people aged 62 and over or chronically ill. In Ojai the exposed group is the City Hall campus encampment: of about 30 campers, half are over 55 and 8 are over 65. The City has a $12.67M state Encampment Resolution grant (April 2024) for permanent supportive housing.

Corrections: the reported death in the island camp could not be confirmed and is dropped. The program is not new; the gap is overflow beyond 40 rooms. The 72-hour notice-to-vacate practice and Turning Point's River Haven were not verified. Clearing camps before a storm without a confirmed bed is advised against (see below).

7. Clear the Fresno Canyon debris basin and its pipe under Highway 33, Stewart Canyon basin, Creek Road culverts, and the Casitas Pass drains

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Ventura County Watershed Protection; County Public Works (Creek Road); Caltrans (Highway 150 drains)	**Inspected and cleared by 15 Nov, and after each storm**	**Existing maintenance budgets**	**Debris overtopping Highway 33 into Casitas Springs, and the mud closures of 2023**

Fresno Canyon debris flooded Casitas Springs three times between 1995 and 2005 and closed Highway 33 for up to two days each time. FEMA funded a $7M project ($5M HMGP and $2M local) for 56 homes in March 2019; construction began in April 2019 and the diversion, with a 9–12 ft pipe under SR-33, was nearly finished by January 2020. New infrastructure still has to be cleared before it can work.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the FEMA release is dated 19 March 2019, not 2025. Creek Road culverts belong to the County, not Caltrans. Whether the Fresno Canyon basin itself is finished, and the state of Stewart Canyon basin, were not verified. The Watershed Protection District's benefit assessments cannot rise without a vote, and its own reports describe a widening gap between revenue and maintenance cost.

8. Check carbon-monoxide alarms, and keep generators outdoors, at least 20 feet from the house

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Ventura County Fire; Ojai Valley CERT; HELP of Ojai; residents	Message out by 1 Nov, before the shutoff season ends and the rains start	Low	CO deaths from generators run in or near homes during outages

The CPSC (2022) attributes about 85 deaths a year to portable generators, 81% of them at homes, and advises keeping generators at least 20 feet from the house. Frequent PSPS shutoffs and a high share of mobile homes make generator use during outages likely here.*

Corrections: the lens paired “85% of engine-related CO deaths” (a 2008 CPSC staff report) with “74% at homes” (a 2014 release); these are older figures from different datasets and should not be combined. No effect size exists for the alarms themselves.

9. Buy flood insurance by about 7 November: the 30-day wait means a January policy misses the storms

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Households; City of Ojai and the *Ojai Valley News* for the reminder	Buy now; cover bought on 8 Oct starts about 7 Nov	Median premium $989 (A zones), $971 (X zones)	Uninsured ruin in a flood; it saves money, not lives

FEMA's OpenFEMA data (v3, as of 8 September 2026) shows 329 NFIP policies in force in ZIP 93023, 213 of them in A zones and 112 in X. Homeowners policies exclude flood, so every other household carries the risk itself. Of 166 claims paid since 1978 ($2.02M nominal), 84 came in 1998 and 2005. Fire cover is moving to the California FAIR Plan (668,609 policies statewide in December 2025, up 146% since September 2022), which covers fire only.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the lens's policy figures (150 A, 95 X; $969 and $857) did not match the live data. The 30-day wait does not apply to policies required at a loan closing. Ranked low because it protects finances, not lives.

10. At the first damaging storm, ask for a Governor's emergency proclamation, which switches on utility shutoff protections

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Sheriff OES (local proclamation and request to Cal OES)	At the first damaging storm	~$0	Households losing power for non-payment while recovering

CPUC Decision D.19-07-015 requires SCE to suspend non-payment disconnections, waive deposits, and offer payment plans for at least 12 months once the Governor or the President proclaims an emergency covering the area. SCE must file within 15 days, and already has under this framework.

Correction: a county-only local emergency does not trigger the protections; the request to Cal OES for a Governor's proclamation is what matters. This is standard practice, not new policy.

11. Give orchard crews a flood and debris-flow message in Spanish and Mixteco, without collecting phone numbers

UNVERIFIED | FRONTLINE · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
MICOP (Radio Indígena), if it confirms reach in the valley; orchard crew leaders	By 1 Dec	$40k, contingent (see funding)	Farmworkers in Upper Ojai and along the creeks missing English-only warnings

MICOP, based in Oxnard, runs Radio Indígena. Enrolment in the county's Mixteco and Zapoteco smoke alerts stalled because “people are not trusting of giving their phone to agencies or strangers,” so organisers signed people up at laundromats.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Not verified: any MICOP presence or Indigenous-language population count in the Ojai Valley. Confirm reach before funding.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	Sheriff OES	VC Fire / Cal OES	County Public Health	SCE	HELP of Ojai	Ojai Valley CERT	City of Ojai	City of Ventura	Watershed / Public Works	Caltrans / CHP	MICOP	Residents
1. Address-level warnings and door knocks	**A/R**	**R**				**R**	**C**		**C**			**R**
2. Device users: Medical Baseline, battery, loan pool			**A**	**R**	**R**	**C**						**R**
3. Stage rescue resources inside the valley	**C**	**A/R**					**I**			**C**		
4. Neighbour pairs and 7–14 day isolation plans			**C**		**A/R**	**R**	**C**					**R**
5. Close flooded crossings; turn around	**A**								**R**	**R**		**R**
6. Storm-night beds for unhoused people	**C**		**C**				**A/R**	**R**				
7. Debris basins and culverts	**I**						**I**		**A/R**	**R**		
8. CO alarms; generators outdoors		**A**		**C**	**R**	**R**						**R**
9. Flood insurance by ~7 Nov							**A**					**R**
10. Governor's proclamation for shutoff protections	**A/R**			**I**			**C**					
11. Spanish and Mixteco message for orchard crews	**C**										**A/R**	**R**

What the chart shows. **Sheriff OES is accountable on three of eleven rows, including the most important one**, so pre-writing the address-level messages is the single biggest dependency. **HELP of Ojai is the valley's only funded channel**, and it appears on three rows although it runs no emergency program today. **Action 6 spans two cities**: Ojai is accountable for its own campus, while the river-bottom camps are Ventura's.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs. No placement carries a measured cost per death averted; amounts are bottom-up unit costs.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
$187k	$407k	$556k	Whether the rain comes; a strong El Niño explains at most about a third of Southern California's rainfall variance

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Floor: HELP of Ojai $77k (60 power stations × ~$650 after SCE's $150 rebate = $39k, plus a $38k phone register) + the first $70k of HELP's displacement cash + $40k of Ventura storm-night overflow = $187k, of which $147k is in the Ojai Valley. **Target:** $77k + $40k + $150k cash + $40k MICOP (contingent on confirmed reach) + $100k VCCF reserve = $407k. **Ceiling:** HELP $116k (120 units) + overflow $100k + cash $150k + MICOP $40k + VCCF $150k = $556k. The target fell 26% in verification, from $550k. HELP of Ojai would receive $227k at target, 13.6% of its FY2025 spending ($1.67M), with $4.31M in net assets. The $650 unit cost is an estimate.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
HELP of Ojai (EIN 95-2872549; FY2025 revenue $2.77M)	Actions 2 and 4: power stations for device users not on Medical Baseline; phone register	$77k	Restricted grant by 1 Nov	60 × ~$650 + $38k; enrol people in Medical Baseline first so SCE's free battery is not duplicated	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
City of Ventura Foul Weather Shelter / Turning Point Foundation (FY2025 revenue $10.29M)	Action 6: overflow beyond Ventura's 40 motel rooms	$40k (was $100k)	Top-up to an existing program	Ventura already runs 40 rooms and holds a $9.8M encampment grant; in Ventura, not the Ojai Valley	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
HELP of Ojai	Flexible cash for displaced families	$150k	Cash, after the event	100 × $1,500; Thomas Fire benchmark $694,621 ÷ 206 families = $3,372. Post-event relief, not prevention	CONFIRMED
Ventura County Community Foundation (FY2025 revenue $25.7M)	Reserve released on an NWS flood warning or a declared emergency	$100k (was $150k)	Pledge, released on trigger	Storm Fund (Jan 2024) raised ~$500k and paid $750–2,000 debit cards, none in Ojai; no trigger-based pledge on record, so it must be negotiated	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
MICOP (FY2025 revenue $10.79M)	Action 11: Spanish and Mixteco warnings	$40k contingent	Direct grant, if reach confirmed	No evidence of work in the Ojai Valley	UNVERIFIED

The funder's one thing: do not spend it all before the storm. A strong El Niño is not a rain forecast for Ojai; 2015–16 proved that. Pre-position the cheap protections now (device power, the register, the overflow beds), and hold the rest at VCCF on a written trigger. If the winter comes in

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

dry, roll it into next autumn's shutoff and smoke season. And the cheapest protection in the valley costs a funder nothing: Sheriff OES pre-writing address-level orders (action 1).

DO NOT DO THIS — CONTRAINDICATED

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives or waste the window here.

Have the City pay flat cash grants to households automatically when the Ojai rain gauge crosses a threshold

CONTRAINDICATED AS WRITTEN

The Economist proposed a council resolution earmarking part of the City's reserve (projected at about $19.5M on 30 June 2026), paid out as flat household grants when rainfall at County gauge 059 (Ojai–Thacher School) passed a debris-flow threshold. No such threshold has been set. Article XVI §6 of the California Constitution bars gifts of public funds. Aid can survive under the public-purpose doctrine with findings tied to a declared emergency and need-based criteria, but flat grants on a rainfall trigger are its weakest form. The roughly $3.3M of headroom above the reserve floor was also not verified.

Instead: route any household cash through VCCF or HELP of Ojai on need-based criteria, and seek a city-attorney opinion before committing City money.

Also avoid (lens advice, consistent with verified evidence): clearing river-bottom or campus camps before a storm with nowhere to go; the 2023 rescue shows people were still there when the water rose. Drawing “voluntary” and “mandatory” zones along roads instead of creeks (Montecito). Relying only on phone alerts in the canyons. “Drive out” plans when Highways 33 and 150 and Casitas Pass close. Indoor generators during outages. Treating the El Niño declaration as the trigger and relaxing if the season starts dry. These come from the Skeptic and other lenses and are consistent with the verified record; they were not separately verified as actions.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Jan–Feb 1969	The valley's biggest flood (weak El Niño): more than 30 in. by 29 January; San Antonio Creek homes destroyed; Casitas Springs and Live Oak Acres flooded	Loss of life confirmed; county-wide count (13 or 10) unverified	A push for flood control; Matilija Dam's capacity cut by silt
Feb 1978	10.36 in. at Ojai, 6.77 in. in 24 hours (weak El Niño); 4 Matilija Canyon homes lost; 8 airlifted	1: Wesley Frazee, heart attack while sandbagging	None recorded
1997–98	Very strong El Niño	40 NFIP claims in ZIP 93023	None recorded
1995–2005	Fresno Canyon debris floods Casitas Springs three times; Highway 33 closed up to 2 days each time	No deaths found	FEMA-funded $7M diversion, 2019–20
Jan 2005	Storm series (weak El Niño); La Conchita landslide on the coast, not in Ojai	44 NFIP claims in 93023; 10 dead at La Conchita	None recorded in the valley
Dec 2017	Thomas Fire rings Ojai; Highways 150 and 33 jammed and closed	1: Virginia Pesola, 70, in a crashed car in Wheeler Canyon, between Santa Paula and Ojai	Post-fire debris warnings; voluntary evacuations in March 2018
9–10 Jan 2023	Atmospheric rivers in a La Niña winter; Highway 33 closed ~32 miles	~70 Matilija residents airlifted; 18 rescued from a Ventura River camp downstream	Highway 33 reopened 18 Dec 2023 after ~$35M of repairs
21 Feb – 31 Jul 2024	Highway 150 landslide at Bridge Rd, north of Santa Paula	No deaths	Retaining wall; five months of detours through Ojai

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Mar 2025	Matilija Dam removal “at least 5 years away”	—	~$250M more needed, ~$30M in hand; downstream levee design under way

The recurrence nobody has noticed: the floods don't change, but the people they hit do. In 1969 and 1978 the victims were trailer residents and canyon homeowners; in 2023 they were people living in the riverbed. Matilija Dam has been “about to come down” for 26 years, so plan this winter as if the levees and the channel are exactly what they were in 2005. And the valley's most common harm has not been drowning but being cut off: in 1978, in 2023, and again in 2024.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **Clear the river-bottom camps before storms** (Historian) versus **never without a bed and transport** (Skeptic). The report adopts the Skeptic's condition: voluntary, to a confirmed bed.
- **Plan for El Niño** (the brief) versus **El Niño barely predicts Ojai's storms** (Skeptic, Historian, Philanthropist). The report triggers on atmospheric-river forecasts.
- **Spend before the peak** versus **hold a third on a trigger** (Philanthropist). Both survive: device power and the register now, the VCCF reserve held.
- **City cash on a gauge trigger** (Economist) versus **the gift-of-public-funds clause** (verification). Moved to contraindicated.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No lens fully covered **autumn wildfire** in the weeks before the rains, beyond PSPS: the Thomas Fire came in December and its one local death was on the evacuation road. No lens looked at **water and sewage**: sewer lines failed in 1969 and spilled into San Antonio Creek in 2005 and 2023, and nobody checked the Casitas Municipal Water District or Ojai's water system during outages. **Hikers and visitors** at Matilija and the hot springs, **care homes**, and access to **Ojai Valley Community Hospital** when roads close were also left out.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

HOW TO READ THIS METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people, and are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; floods, debris flows, outages, and fire are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named “Ojai, California”. It is treated as the City of Ojai plus the unincorporated Ojai Valley (Meiners Oaks, Mira Monte, Oak View, Casitas Springs, Upper Ojai, Matilija Canyon). Climate Impact Lab impact region, as this report records it: Ventura County, CA, *inferred* rather than resolved on the Impact Map. Most local statistics are for ZIP/ZCTA 93023 (21,036 people), which covers Ojai, Meiners Oaks, Mira Monte, and the canyons, and 93022 (Oak View). The river-bottom camps and the 2023 rescue are in the City of Ventura, downstream.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Heat is not this place's winter hazard, so the historical record carries the hazard instead.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, and philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias: five lenses converged on river-bottom evacuation, and verification found the camps are in Ventura and a program already exists, so the action was re-aimed at Ojai's own campus and at overflow. Contradictions were kept. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, given payers or marked unfunded, and reconciled against the funding placements.
- **Verification.** Six separate verifier agents checked 12 recommendations, the historical record, and the funding placements on evidence, transferability, and feasibility. Financial actions were also checked for availability, a named payer, a trigger, and whether they are already

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implemented. Verifiers queried HHS emPOWER and OpenFEMA (NFIP policies v3 and claims) directly, and read IRS filings on ProPublica. The envelope was re-summed.

- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted earlier the same day (8 October 2026) by driving the inventory's map interface in a browser for the Elmwood briefing; the US filter returns 19 entries, none covering address-level debris-flow warnings, device-user batteries, rescue pre-staging, or isolation rosters. It was not re-driven for this location. Actions are tagged “none found” on that basis.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (evacuation, medical equipment in an outage, driving into floodwater, and generators) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total. Lens unit costs are labelled estimates. No local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. Three verifiers exhausted their search budgets, so some items are marked unverified. No 2026-season burn scar above the valley was found, but the USGS and CAL FIRE 2026 lists could not be opened; check before relying on the debris-flow ranking. ENSO phases are from the verifiers' recall of NOAA's ONI table. Valley-specific death counts for 1969, 1983, 1998, and 2005 were not found.

References · verified by Phase 5 unless marked. HHS emPOWER REST service (queried 8 Oct 2026) · Census Reporter, ZCTA 93023 (verified) · SCE Critical Care Backup Battery (verified) · SCE backup power rebates (corrected) · City of Ojai, power outages (verified) · SCE 2020 PSPS frequent circuits (verified) · Harding et al. 2026, PSPS and ED visits (verified) · Montecito evacuation zones (verified) · Montecito contradictory warnings (corrected) · NWS/University of Alabama survey (corrected) · UCSB 2021, evacuation compliance (verified) · Ventura County named-area orders, Feb 2024 (verified) · Ashley & Ashley 2008 (corrected) · CIRA 2025, inland flood deaths (verified) · Cal OES pre-positioning (verified) · Matilija airlift, Jan 2023 (verified) · Caltrans SR-33 repairs (verified) · Caltrans SR-150 recovery (verified) · HELP of Ojai transportation (verified) · Ojai Valley CERT (verified) · Ventura River rescue, Jan 2023 (verified) · 18 rescued from island camp (verified) · Ventura Foul Weather Shelter Plan (verified) · Ventura encampment grant (verified) · Ojai encampment grant (verified) · Ojai City Hall campus campers (verified) · FEMA, Casitas Springs project (2019) (corrected) · Fresno Canyon construction (verified) · Watershed Protection benefit assessment (lens) · CPSC generator CO report, 2022 (verified) · OpenFEMA NFIP policies v3 (queried) · OpenFEMA NFIP claims (queried) · California FAIR Plan growth (lens) · SCE emergency protections filing (verified) · City of Ojai 2025–26 budget (verified) · VCCF Storm Fund (verified) · Parametric

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insurance (Jumpstart) (verified) · HELP of Ojai, IRS filings (verified) · HELP of Ojai Thomas Fire relief (verified) · Turning Point Foundation, IRS filings (verified) · MICOP, IRS filings (verified) · Mixteco and Zapoteco alerts (lens) · Ojai history, 1969 (verified) · Ojai history, 1978 (verified) · Thomas Fire death (verified) · Matilija Dam status, 2025 (verified) · Why 2015–16 was dry (lens) · NOAA, El Niño and SoCal rainfall (lens) · NOAA ONI table (lens, recalled) · USGS post-fire debris-flow assessments (not opened)

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory (US)

Generated 8 October 2026 for Ojai, California. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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